Published by a fencing parent with a bot.

The EN GARDE GAZETTE
THE ELITE FENCERS CLUB WEEKLY

It is better to deserve a rating than to have one.

MONDAY EDITION
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Vet Worlds, Part Two: Two World Titles for U.S. Women

The U.S. women's epee veterans left the Veteran World Championships in Tbilisi, Georgia, with two world titles and four individual medals.

Leslie Marx led the way in Veteran 50, working through an 83-fencer field and beating Belgium's Nathalie Vandewalle 10-4 in the final. The FIE says it was her first title in the event since 2017.

The Veteran 40 gold came down to one touch. Cassandra Bates lost the final 10-9 to Julia Ashchuk and took silver, and Lacey Biniak, who fell to Ashchuk 10-8 in the semifinals, took bronze. That gave the U.S. two of the four medals in a 63-fencer field. In Veteran 70, Charlotta Bowie won bronze after a 10-7 semifinal loss to Germany's Astrid Kircheis, the eventual champion.

Then came the team event. In a field of 19 teams, the U.S. beat Italy 45-40 in the semifinals and France 45-31 in the final for gold.

The championships, held Oct. 9–17, drew 1,273 athletes from 65 nations. The women's epee events ran Oct. 12–14.

Controversial Calls: The Touch Only the Referee Thought She Saw

Editor's note: The fencer in this story is the editor's son.

The light went on, and the argument started. In a pool bout at a national tournament two years ago, an Elite FC fencer's opponent scored a touch that, the fencer's family says, landed off the strip. The fencer said the blade never hit him.

By the family's account, the opponent waved a hand to signal no touch, the Elite FC coach pointed that out on the spot, and neither the opponent's coach nor family said a word in the touch's defense. The only person who thought it was a touch, the family says, was the referee, who said she thought she saw it hit. The fencer made a formal appeal, and the Head Referee came over and ruled that it was the referee's call. Pools had no video replay. The fencer lost the bout by one touch.

On paper, a hit that misses the fencer shouldn't count. In epee, touches "made on the ground where it is not insulated" are disregarded (t.93), and a touch that lands on the strip and registers is annulled (t.94.1). The catch is who decides whether it landed. That is a "point of fact," and against a point of fact "no appeal can be made" (t.172.1). An appeal can challenge only how a rule was applied, and the Head Referee settles it (t.172.2, t.174). No rule we found gives an opponent's signal any formal weight.

Both sides (opinion). For the call: the referee judges from where she stands, and making her view final keeps bouts from being re-argued touch by touch. Against it: when the fencer who scored signals a miss, a referee who only thought she saw a hit has a thin basis for a decisive touch.

The verdict: judgment call. On the family's own account, the Head Referee applied the rules correctly. A referee's view of a hit can't be appealed, no matter how differently it looked from the side of the strip.

For parents, the lesson is narrow but useful. You can't appeal what a referee saw, only how a rule was applied. Only the fencer can appeal, and it has to happen right away, before the next touch. At national tournaments today, video replay is guaranteed only in later direct-elimination rounds (from the round of 16 or 8, depending on the event), not in pools. And a parent's phone video doesn't count.

World No. 1's Message to His Future Self

After a quarterfinal loss at the Tokyo Olympics, Egypt's Mohamed Elsayed recorded a private video message to himself: a promise that came true with a bronze medal at Paris 2024, Egypt's first Olympic fencing medal in 12 years. Now ranked No. 1 in the world in men's epee, he tells Team USA epeeist Ari Simmons the story on the FIE's podcast "The Will to Win" (Episode 3). His advice: "Fencing is like life. There's always a comeback in life, and there's always a comeback in fencing." Listen on the FIE's YouTube channel.

PHOTO FROM HISTORY

1965: Club Epee, With Everyone Close Enough to Watch



Laurens van Tiggele, left, faces Raoul Popken at the Dutch national team epee championship in Amsterdam's Oude RAI on Nov. 21, 1965. The winning club was Zaal Abrahamse of The Hague; spectators and another bout fill the space behind the two fencers.

Look closely and a body cord trails from the nearest fencer.

Photo: unknown photographer / Anefo, Nationaal Archief, collection 2.24.01.05, no. 918-4711 (Nov. 21, 1965). CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-resolution JPEG converted from the archive's original TIFF. Cropped. Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Duel_tussen_Van_Tiggele_(links)_en_Popken,_Bestanddeelnr_918-4711.jpg.

NEARBY TOURNAMENTS — ELITE FC ENTRIES

MORRIS CUP RYC/RJCC · Suffern, N.Y. · Sat., Oct. 24

TIME	EVENT	ELITE FC
8:00 AM	Junior Women	Amina Gore, Olivia Hayes, Anayaa Sheth
8:00 AM	Y12 Men	Kian Jaising, Joshua Jeong, Remy Ng
12:30 PM	Cadet Men	Pablo Aguirre, Connor Anderson, Nico Ng, Caden Wu
3:00 PM	Y14 Women	Stella Kuo, Mila Siu

ULTIMATE CUP RJCC · Hillsborough, N.J. · Oct. 31–Nov. 1

DAY	EVENT	ELITE FC
Sat 10/31	Junior Women	Olivia Hayes, Anayaa Sheth, Adela Sullivan
Sat 10/31	Cadet Men	Maksim Milinkovic, Caden Wu
Sun 11/1	Junior Men	Pablo Aguirre, Dieko Johnson, Maksim Milinkovic, Nico Ng
Sun 11/1	Cadet Women	Olivia Hayes, Lillian Liu, Adela Sullivan, Penny Young

MORRIS CUP RYC/RJCC · Suffern, N.Y. · Sun., Oct. 25

TIME	EVENT	ELITE FC
8:00 AM	Cadet Women	Amina Gore, Olivia Hayes, Adela Sullivan, Penny Young
8:00 AM	Junior Men	Pablo Aguirre, Nico Ng
10:00 AM	Y8 Women	Madeline Siu
10:30 AM	Y12 Women	Christina Jiang, Stella Kuo, Mila Siu
1:30 PM	Y14 Men	Connor Anderson, Noah Gore, Kian Jaising, Remy Ng, Ash Shah-Mirani
3:30 PM	Y10 Men	Bryce Cheng, Joshua Jeong, Maximus Siu

MEDEO YOUTH CHALLENGES · Bound Brook, N.J.

DAY	NO.	ELITE FC
Sun 10/25	#4	Nora Li (Y10 Mixed)
Sun 11/8	#5	Samuel SarroWaite (Y12 Men), Christina Jiang (Y12 Women), Nora Li (Y10 Mixed), Owen Li (Y14 Men)

Morris Cup is at Rockland Community College's Eugene Levy Field House: 20 Elite FC fencers, 30 entries. Ultimate Cup is at Iron Peak Sports & Events in Hillsborough: 10 Elite FC fencers, 13 entries.

DEADLINES

DATE	WHAT CLOSES
Thu 10/22	Morris Cup: last day to enter (late fees)
Thu 10/29	Ultimate Cup: last day to enter (late fees)
Sun 11/1	Cobra Challenge (Secaucus, Nov. 27–29): regular entry closes; late entry to Nov. 7
Wed 11/11	Junior Olympics: regular-fee deadline
Fri 1/8	N.J. high school: independent fencers' entries close

Tournament deadlines are 11:59 p.m. Pacific (2:59 a.m. Eastern the next day), from the USA Fencing pages.

N.J. High School Fencing: 2026–27 Dates Are Set

High-school season: tryouts Nov. 23–25, first practice Nov. 30, and competition may begin Dec. 7.

Independent fencers' entries close Jan. 8, 2027.

Team state finals are Feb. 25 at Morris Hills; individual states are Feb. 27 at Hunterdon Central.

BY THE BOOK

You Can't Appeal What the Referee Saw

A referee's ruling on what happened on the strip, like whether a hit landed or a fencer stepped off the side, is a "point of fact," and it can't be appealed (t.172). Argue a point of fact during the bout, or make an appeal the Head Referee finds unjustified (t.174), and it's a First Group offense: a yellow card the first time, then a red card (a penalty touch) for each repeat in that bout (t.165). Appeal the rule, not the call.

FOR THE PARENTS

Qualifying Isn't Registering

Qualifying isn't the same as registering. A fencer who earns a Junior Olympics spot, including through a division qualifier, still has to sign up; USA Fencing says it does not register anyone automatically. Register by the Nov. 11 regular-fee deadline, even if a fencer's qualifier comes later; the entry stays "pending" until qualification is confirmed. Division results can take two to five days to reach USA Fencing. The 2027 Junior Olympics run Jan. 8–11 in Oklahoma City.

Class Notes

Saturday group classes: Musketeers at 11 a.m., Advanced at 1 p.m.

Fridays: Mini Musketeers at 4:15 p.m., then open bouting in the evening.

Overheard on Reddit: After the Split

After October's NAC, the first with fields split into Elite and Challenger, r/Fencing compared notes. The top-voted take came from a fan of the change: top fencers used to get easy pools and early DEs, and now they meet strong opponents every round. One fencer placed in Elite called it the most concentrated U.S. event they'd seen. Another put it simply: "Pools was tough but it was a lot more fun." Not everyone was sold. One poster said coaches found the day brutal, for them and for referees, and another argued the tiers reflect how active a fencer is more than how strong. Others said it's too early to judge from one event, and several want the 20% pool cut dropped in Challenger.

Fact check: *Fields are set by Unified Points List rank 15 days out. In Cadet, an Elite top-64 finish (51.6 points) outscores a Challenger top-16 finish (49.2).*

Winter Camp: Sign Up Now

Elite FC Winter Camp runs Dec. 27–31, 9:30 a.m. to 2 p.m., and it's open to all levels: footwork, technical and tactical drills, strength and conditioning, and games. Call it a tune-up for the second half of the season, or a good excuse to escape visiting relatives for a few hours. The club asks campers to register as soon as possible; contact the club for price and sign-up.